

THE SEVENTH GUIDE IN THE PEEP & BEYOND PARENT SERIES

Potty Training, One Step at a Time

A parent's field guide to potty-training readiness, methods, and mindset for children roughly 18 months to 5 — with notes on nighttime training and setbacks up to age 7 — grounded in the latest pediatric guidance.



BEFORE YOU START

About this guide

Somewhere between the first "I don't want a diaper" and the day underwear finally sticks, most families hit a stretch of accidents, resistance, and second-guessing. If potty training feels harder than the parenting books made it sound, you're not doing it wrong — every child gets there on their own timeline. This guide unpacks what readiness actually looks like, a calm four-step method for the training window itself, and how to handle accidents and setbacks without shame — for either of you.

What's inside

Why physical and developmental readiness matters more than a birthday, what training looks like across three practical stages, a repeatable four-step method for the daily rhythm of training, ready-to-use scripts for encouraging use of the potty and handling accidents, the habits that quietly slow training down, and how to build a calmer routine at home, day and night.

The approach behind it

This guide draws on the American Academy of Family Physicians' review of toilet-training readiness and methods, the American Academy of Pediatrics' guidance on toilet training and nighttime dryness, a Canadian Medical Association Journal review comparing child-oriented and structured training approaches, and Cleveland Clinic and Mayo Clinic guidance on toilet-training practice and troubleshooting. Full sources are listed at the end.

Continuing the series

This is Guide 7 of the Peep & Beyond Parent Series. In Guide 1, *When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper*, we introduced the C.A.L.M. Path for big emotions in the moment. In Guide 2, *Screens & Big Feelings*, we built the P.A.C.E. Method for hard transitions. Potty training brings both of those skills together — big feelings and a transition, several times a day — so don't be surprised if a few ideas here feel familiar.

A note before you continue: This guide is educational and is not a substitute for medical advice. If you have concerns about your child's toileting, bladder or bowel habits, or physical development, please speak with your pediatrician — reaching out is a sign of good parenting, not a failure of it.

CONTENTS

What you'll find inside

01	Why Readiness Matters More Than Age	04
	What physical and developmental readiness actually looks like	
02	Three Stages of the Journey	05
	From not-yet-ready to mostly there, with room to move at your child's pace	
03	The S.T.E.P. Method	07
	A simple four-step way to build the daily rhythm of training	
04	Scripts You Can Use	09
	Exact words for encouraging the potty, accidents, and public restrooms	
05	Common Mistakes	10
	Habits that quietly slow potty training down	
06	Building a Calmer Training Routine	11
	Sits, clothing, praise, and a separate timeline for nights	
07	When to Reach Out	13
	Signs it's worth a conversation with a professional	
08	Quick Reference Sheet	14
	One page to print and keep on the fridge	

SECTION 01

Why Readiness Matters More Than Age

There's no single birthday when a child becomes "ready" for the potty — readiness is a set of physical and developmental skills that show up on their own timeline, sometimes as early as 18 months and sometimes closer to 3. Starting before those skills are in place doesn't speed things up — it usually just adds frustration for both of you.

What readiness actually looks like

Three things tend to arrive together: bladder control (staying dry for a stretch of an hour or two, noticing the sensation of needing to go before or as it happens), communication (words, signs, or a clear pull at a wet diaper), and a pinch of independence (wanting to imitate a sibling or parent, pulling at clothing, showing interest in the bathroom). All three matter more than the number on a calendar.

Why starting too early backfires

A child whose body and vocabulary aren't quite there yet can't succeed no matter how consistent the schedule is — and repeated "failures" at this stage tend to build frustration and power struggles that make the eventual, real training window harder, not easier. Waiting for readiness isn't slower parenting; it's usually the faster path overall.

RESEARCH NOTE

A review in *American Family Physician* found that starting toilet training before 18 months does not shorten the overall time to being fully trained, and can extend it — while training that begins once a child shows clear readiness signs, generally between 18 and 30 months, tends to go more smoothly and finish sooner.

KEEP IN MIND

Girls often show readiness a couple of months before boys on average, and every child's pace varies — comparing your child's timeline to a sibling's or a friend's rarely helps, and often adds pressure that isn't useful to either of you.

SECTION 02

Three Stages of the Journey

Instead of a strict age chart, think of potty training as three stages your child moves through at their own pace — some quickly, some with pauses in between.

NOT READY YET · UNDER ~18–24 MONTHS

At this stage, most toddlers don't yet have the muscle control or body awareness to notice the need to go before it happens, and words for it are still new or missing. This is completely normal, not a delay — the nerves and muscles involved in bladder and bowel control are still maturing.

Pushing training now usually means a lot of effort for very little progress, and can turn the bathroom into a source of tension before your child is even able to succeed there.

What helps most: talk about body parts and bathroom routines in an ordinary, unpressured way, let your child watch a parent or older sibling use the toilet if that happens naturally, and keep a potty chair around as a piece of furniture, not a task — curiosity is enough for now.

READY & TRAINING · ROUGHLY AGES 2–4

This is the core training window for most children. Readiness signs to watch for: staying dry for an hour or two, telling you before or during the fact, showing interest in underwear or the toilet, following simple two-step instructions, and discomfort with a dirty diaper. Most children complete daytime training somewhere around age 3, though a wide range around that is entirely normal.

Both a gentle, child-led approach and a more structured, concentrated approach (sometimes called a "3-day method") can work well — the right one depends on your child's temperament and your family's schedule, not which is objectively "better."

What helps most: a predictable daily rhythm of potty sits, clothing your child can manage independently, and treating accidents as information rather than a failure.

MOSTLY THERE · ROUGHLY AGES 4–8

Daytime training is largely in place, but a few things still need their own timeline. Nighttime dryness usually lags months to years behind daytime control, since it depends on a different kind of bladder maturity that develops on its own schedule — occasional bedwetting up to about age 7 is common and not a cause for concern on its own.

Regression — a previously trained child suddenly having frequent accidents — is common around a new sibling, a house move, starting school, or another big change, and almost always resolves with patience rather than punishment.

What helps most: treating nighttime training as separate from daytime, keeping the response to any accident calm and matter-of-fact, and giving a regression time and reassurance rather than urgency.

SECTION 03

The S.T.E.P. Method

A simple four-step way to build the daily rhythm of training — less about a single big "potty training day" and more about a pattern your child can lean on.

1

Spot the Signs — confirm readiness before you start

Before starting, look for the readiness signs together rather than picking a start date off a calendar: dry stretches, discomfort with a soiled diaper, interest in the bathroom, and the words or gestures to signal a need. Starting once two or three of these are showing up consistently sets the whole process up to go faster, not slower.

2

Try the Routine — build predictable potty sits

Offer a calm, short sit on the potty at predictable points in the day — after waking, after meals, before leaving the house — rather than only asking "do you need to go?" in the moment. A consistent rhythm does more of the work than any single reminder, and it takes the pressure off any one sit needing to "succeed."

3

Ease Into Accidents — respond without shame

Accidents are part of learning, not a sign training is failing. A calm, neutral response — "accidents happen, let's get you changed" — teaches far more than frustration does, and keeps the bathroom a safe place rather than one your child starts to dread or hide from.

4

Praise the Progress — celebrate without overdoing it

Warm, specific praise for trying and for successes — "you told me in time, that was great listening to your body" — builds confidence better than elaborate reward systems, which can start to feel like the whole point and lose their effect once the novelty wears off.

RESEARCH NOTE

A review in the *Canadian Medical Association Journal* comparing child-oriented approaches (gradual, following the child's cues) with more structured, intensive approaches (concentrated practice over a few days) found both can succeed — the meaningful differences tend to show up in stress and pace, not in which method is more "correct." Most pediatric guidance favors starting with a child-oriented approach and adjusting from there.

SECTION 04

Scripts You Can Use

A few ready phrases for encouraging potty use, handling accidents, and easing public-restroom worries.

SITUATION	SAY THIS	WHY IT HELPS
Encouraging a sit	"Let's go try, even if nothing happens — that still counts."	Takes the pressure off "success" and keeps the routine low-stakes.
An accident happens	"Accidents happen. Let's get you changed, and try again next time."	Calm and matter-of-fact prevents shame from attaching to the bathroom.
Public restroom worry	"It's a different bathroom, but it works the same way. I'll stay right here with you."	Names the unfamiliarity instead of dismissing it, and offers reassurance.
Nighttime setback / regression	"Your body is still learning to do this at night — that's not something you did wrong."	Separates nighttime dryness from daytime success and removes blame.

TIP

Keep the tone light and matter-of-fact, especially around accidents — a big reaction, even a sympathetic one, can make the moment feel bigger and more charged than it needs to.

SECTION 05

Common Mistakes

Every one of these is an understandable response to a messy, tiring process — most parents have reached for a few of them. Here's what tends to help less than it seems like it should, and what to try instead.

Tends to backfire

- Punishing or shaming a child for an accident
- Starting training right after a move, new sibling, or other big change
- Comparing progress to a sibling's or friend's timeline
- Using pull-ups as a permanent stand-in for real practice
- Forcing a sit when a child is upset or resisting
- Asking "do you need to go?" over and over instead of a routine
- Making a big deal — good or bad — out of every single accident

Works better

- A calm, neutral response, every time
- Waiting for a settled stretch to begin or restart training
- Following your own child's pace and readiness signs
- Using pull-ups as a bridge, with a clear plan to move off them
- Offering a sit, then letting your child decide
- A predictable rhythm of sits built into the day
- Treating accidents as information, not a big event

RESEARCH NOTE

Pediatric guidance consistently points to constipation and stool withholding as one of the most common, overlooked causes of daytime accidents and stalled training — a full bowel can press on the bladder and make bladder control much harder, regardless of how consistent the potty routine is.

SECTION 06

Building a Calmer Training Routine

The goal isn't a flawless week of no accidents — it's a routine steady enough that most days don't turn into a battle.

Build sits into the day, not just the moment

Short, predictable sits — on waking, after meals, before leaving the house — do more than reactive reminders. A timer or a favorite short book kept just for potty time can make the sit itself something your child doesn't mind.

Dress for independence

Loose, easy-to-manage pants with an elastic waist let your child get to the potty and undress in time without needing help every single time — a small thing that removes a lot of friction, especially early on.

Praise the effort, not just the outcome

Specific, warm praise for trying, for noticing a body signal, or for getting close in time builds real confidence. Save elaborate reward charts for cases where extra motivation genuinely helps — most children respond just as well to attention and encouragement.

Keep nighttime on its own timeline

Daytime and nighttime control develop separately, and nighttime usually comes later — sometimes much later. Pull-ups or a mattress protector at night are a practical bridge, not a step backward, until your child consistently wakes up dry.

FROM GUIDE 1 — THIS STILL APPLIES

Accidents can bring up big feelings for a child — embarrassment, frustration, sometimes a meltdown that has nothing to do with the accident itself. The C.A.L.M. Path from *When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper* works here too: get close, name the feeling, and hold the moment steady before moving on to changing clothes and trying again.

Model calm, even when you don't feel it

A frustrated sigh or a sharp tone after the fifth accident of the day is completely human — and also worth catching where you can. Children pick up on a parent's tension around the bathroom quickly, and a calmer parent tends to raise a calmer, faster-training child.

SECTION 07

When to Reach Out

Some accidents, resistance, and slow stretches are a normal part of potty training. A few patterns are worth a conversation with your pediatrician:

- Daytime wetting continues consistently past age 5, despite a steady routine
- Your child cries out or complains of pain or burning during urination
- Signs of chronic constipation or stool withholding — infrequent, hard, or painful bowel movements, or soiling accidents alongside them
- A sudden, complete regression that follows a frightening event or lasts more than a few weeks without easing
- Your child seems afraid of the toilet itself, beyond ordinary reluctance
- Blood in the urine, or a strong odor or fever alongside accidents

PLEASE REMEMBER

Reaching out for support is not a sign that you've failed as a parent — it's one of the most effective things you can do for your child. A pediatrician can check for a physical cause, like constipation or a urinary tract infection, and help build a plan suited to your child specifically.

SECTION 08 • PRINT & KEEP

Quick Reference

Keep this page on the fridge for the next stage of the potty training journey.

The S.T.E.P. Method

1. **Spot the Signs** — confirm readiness first
2. **Try the Routine** — build predictable sits
3. **Ease Into Accidents** — respond without shame
4. **Praise the Progress** — celebrate without overdoing it

Say this

"Let's go try, even if nothing happens."
"Accidents happen. Let's try again."
"Your body is still learning — at night too."

Skip this

Shaming accidents · starting during a big transition · comparing to siblings · forcing a sit

Remember

Readiness beats a birthday. Routine beats reminders. Nighttime has its own timeline.

Reach out if...

Daytime wetting continues past age 5 · pain during urination · signs of constipation or withholding · a regression that doesn't ease after a few weeks → talk to your pediatrician.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Where this guide comes from

American Academy of Family Physicians. "Toilet Training: Common Questions and Answers" — readiness signs, timing, and methods.

American Academy of Pediatrics / HealthyChildren.org. Guidance on toilet training and nighttime bedwetting (nocturnal enuresis).

Canadian Medical Association Journal (CMAJ). Review: "Toilet training children: when to start and how to train" — comparing child-oriented and structured methods.

Cleveland Clinic. Toilet-training tips, troubleshooting, and the 3-day method.

Mayo Clinic. "Potty training: How to get the job done."

This guide is part of the Peep & Beyond Parent Series, created to give parents clear, research-informed support for the everyday moments of raising kids — including the messy, wonderful process of growing out of diapers. It is educational in nature and does not replace individualized medical care.

With you, one small step at a time.

— Peep & Beyond